

France Itinerary

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Paris 2022: Three Days with the Iron Lady, Macarons & Mixed Feelings

Paris is not a place that can be covered in few days, and definitely not in my few words. Whenever you think of it, you can have different words for it. The ones I keep coming back to are: little overhyped, confused emotion, a sense of belonging and being outcasted at the same time. We rolled into Paris from Prague after a 13-hour bus ride I'd booked by mistake (long story), and we left it three days later with our hearts full, our feet wrecked, and a parcel of half-eaten pasta we still regret throwing away.

This is our honest diary from August 2022 — me and Harshit, two Indians doing Europe on a tight schedule, trying to squeeze the city for everything it had while also not pretending it was perfect. Paris was both: the dream studio I'd always pictured, and the museum painting that disappointed. Both, often in the same afternoon.

Day 1

Bercy Seine, the Iron Lady & a 10:40pm Cruise

We reached **Bercy Seine** station after the longest bus ride of our lives. The plan had originally been a RegioJet train from Prague, which I confidently booked — except the booking turned out to be a 13-hour overnight bus. Harshit took it well, as he takes most of my blunders. The bus was actually fine; my pride was the only casualty. We took the old, slightly intimidating Paris metro to **Trocadero**, dragged our suitcases across cobblestones, and got our first eyeful of the Iron Lady. There she was — exactly like in the photos, except she was real and we were tired.

From Trocadero we dragged the suitcases the rest of the way to our studio apartment at **43 Rue Spontini**. I will always be thankful to Harshit for booking that one. I had earlier complained it was costly, but it was worth every penny. That studio was very much like what I had imagined I'd own once I started earning — small, smart, full of light — but it's still not the kind of place I've managed to build for myself in India. I got to live in one because of Harshit and Airbnb, and even now I think about that little flat.

We could not stay long though. A short power nap, a face wash, and we were back out for the **Hop on Hop off**. Honest note for any future traveller: the Paris bus is slow. Painfully slow compared to Vienna and Prague. By the time we'd done a partial loop, our priorities had quietly rearranged themselves — and from this bus seat onwards, we decided that the food included in our Paris pass was top priority and museums were bottom priority. We followed that rule diligently for the rest of the trip.

For dinner we ate pizza near the Eiffel Tower, then joined the queue for the river cruise. The queue was endless. We wanted a night cruise anyway, so the wait was almost a blessing — we ended up with the second-last cruise of the day, the 10:40pm one. While waiting, we got chatting with an Indian couple living in the Netherlands; that little homesick swap of "where in India are you from" made the wait feel shorter. The cruise itself was lovely. Every monument under the night sky and artificial lights looks like a different city. It was technically the same daylight tour we'd already done on the Hop on Hop off, but the night air turned it into something else. We were tourists and we did the touristy thing on Day 1 — we watched the Iron Lady until our eyes closed on their own.

Day 2

Café Louise, the Mona Lisa Letdown & Rain in Montmartre

Day 2 was jam-packed, and to our own surprise we hit every checkpoint ahead of schedule. We started with breakfast at **Café Louise**. From this morning onwards, almost everything we ate was included in our Go City pass, and we'd quietly planned every meal, snack and drink before even leaving India. At Louise, the croissants were fantastic — I can never spell the word right but the taste was perfect — and honestly every item on the menu seemed to work.

Then we walked over to the famous **Louvre**. We picked a good spot outside and did a slightly weird photoshoot before going in, because we knew the inside would be all about one thing: the Mona Lisa. We walked straight to her room. There's a separate queue just to look at the painting. And then there she was — the 1st most disappointing thing of our entire trip. Smaller than I'd imagined, mobbed by phones, behind layers of glass and shoulders. We clicked our share of random Louvre shots and left.

Next stop was **Flyview** Paris — a 360° virtual reality tour of the city. When we reached, we got told we could pick a second show as well, so we ended up with two and both were thrilling. We left Flyview still early for our next booking, the **Montmartre** walking tour. The weather had turned perfect: no harsh sun, a little drizzle. A train got cancelled, we struggled with the map, climbed approximately a hundred stairs and arrived a little flustered but on time.

And then Montmartre quietly stole the day. The vibe was great — restaurants spilling onto the streets, cafés humming, artists lined up sketching caricatures. We walked in expecting a glass of champagne and a snack with our pass. Instead the restaurant pulled out a whole menu — starters, mains, desserts. After much deliberation we ended up with a cheese starter, two mains (a pasta and a burger), and two desserts (fruit salad and a chocolate brownie). The burger was better than the pasta. I couldn't finish my pasta and asked them to parcel it; we got a neat little box that we sadly never ate from. We rushed to the tour with about fifteen minutes to spare and made it.

Our tour guide had warnings galore about Paris, but we were lucky and had no bad experiences. He shared the strangest trivia — that pressing the **Dalida** statue's bust is supposed to bring you a partner, despite Dalida herself having three difficult marriages, two husbands who died by suicide, and eventually a tragic end of her own. Montmartre's hilltop is full of windmills and old beer-brewing history; it also has the famous Moulin Rouge, which we walked past but didn't watch. After the tour we took our photos at **Sacré-Cœur**, then got hopelessly lost trying to find the macaron and ice-cream shop the guide had recommended. We saw the love wall while wandering, window-shopped past some very Parisian shops, and by the time we found the macaron place we were completely drenched. The rain in Paris is its own character. We ate Parisian ice cream, packed every macaron flavour, and walked back through wet streets buying bread on the way. Rain and Paris had done something to my heart that night.

Day 3: 15th August

Climbing the Iron Lady & Saying Goodbye

Day 3 was Indian Independence Day, and we were running late. We overslept, made pav bhaji for breakfast, and decided to throw the leftover Montmartre pasta — a decision I still regret because I was just too full at that moment to honour it. Our morning slot was the Eiffel Tower walking tour, and we literally ran through the streets to **Trocadero**. The view from there is spectacular, the kind that stops you mid-step, but we had no time to admire it. We sprinted straight to the meeting point and slid into the queue just in time.

Our guide was **Hexcel**, and he was excellent. The tour started with the long queues, a couple of dumb security checks, a fun guessing game about the tower's history, and then the actual climb. By halfway to the first floor we were panting; the group's energy pulled us up. From the first floor, Hexcel ran us through the tower's history and a string of facts about the city. The view is genuinely nice, though the

place is heavily commercialised — from the outside you can't tell how much is happening inside her. One of the more bizarre facts: there's a small **Statue of Liberty** up there facing New York, and most of these famous statues were originally gifts between cities. We went up to the second floor for a few more clicks, said goodbye to the Iron Lady, and walked back to Rue Spontini to shift our luggage into lockers.

On the way back to the studio, we spotted other Indians waving the Indian flag at Trocadero. It being 15th August, we did what any homesick Indians abroad would do — we got the flag, took a stack of photos, and basked in a tiny pocket of India in front of the Iron Lady. Saying goodbye to the studio at 43 Rue Spontini was harder than it had any right to be. The Indian gentleman at the luggage locker shop refused to let us use his wifi, which was a small heartbreak; we eventually borrowed wifi from a nearby café and re-planned the rest of the afternoon.

We tried a crêpe at a nearby restaurant — and that's our second disappointment of Paris. I think mine was egg-based and I really didn't enjoy it. Then back to **Café Louise** for a light snack and cocktails. We picked two different ones, an orange-based and a coconut-based, and somehow finished both. By the end of it I had confirmed for myself that I am not really an alcohol person; even the dilute versions weren't doing much for me.

We tried to claim our free goodies at BAPAP, got lost without internet, and reached to find the shop closed. So we made our way to **Montparnasse** — a 56-floor tower with a sweeping view of the city, and a quieter, less-photographed alternative to the Eiffel. By then we were hungry and behind schedule. We collected our luggage and headed for Bercy Seine, taking two buses instead of the metro because dragging suitcases on roads is easier than lifting them up metro stairs. Our second bus was so late we nearly took a cab. While we were waiting at the stop, an open dance session broke out — I don't remember the music or the dance form, but it was the kind of golden, unplanned European evening I'd love to live again. We finally caught the FlixBus to Zurich and said our hard goodbye to Paris with hungry stomachs and heavy hearts. Sayonara to Paris.

Our Honest Take on Paris

So — did Paris live up to the hype? Sort of. Sometimes. In flashes. The Iron Lady was mesmerising, the Mona Lisa wasn't. The studio felt like a dream, the Louvre felt like a queue. At one point you want to live in this city for years; another time it feels like it has nothing more to give you. That contradiction is, I think, the most honest thing I can say about it.

Paris is a place who is holding a lot, and seen a lot in the past. The city that can act as a mirror and reflects your mood. The Iron Lady can be mesmerising, or wasteful, or worthless — depending on which perception you are looking from.

We had started watching *Emily in Paris* just before the trip, and once we got there the streets and corners from the show kept feeling familiar — like we'd walked them in a past life on a laptop screen. That, combined with the studio on Rue Spontini that matched the apartment I've quietly fantasised about for years, gave the city a strange, almost personal grip. It wasn't just a holiday. It was a checklist of small, private dreams getting ticked off, even though I hadn't realised I'd written them down.

We came back to Mumbai a week later and I'm writing some of this from there. Not a single day has passed without one of us missing European food or weather or pace. I think travelling is a next-level addiction — the planning, the running for buses, the bad crêpes, the great macarons, all of it. After Paris, the will to come back isn't a question of *if*, it's only ever about *when*.

Must-Do Things in Paris (Our 3-Day List)

- **Eiffel Tower Walking Tour:** Climb to the 1st and 2nd floors with a guide — the trivia is half the fun.

- **Café Louise:** Breakfast croissants, and yes, cocktails later in the day.
- **Trocadero View:** The classic Iron Lady postcard view — best at golden hour.
- **Flyview Paris:** A 360° VR ride over Paris; ask for the second show.
- **Montmartre Walking Tour:** Dalida trivia, Moulin Rouge, hilltop windmills and the included meal.
- **The Macaron & Ice-Cream Shop** (Montmartre): Worth getting drenched in the rain for.
- **Montparnasse 56th Floor:** A quieter city-wide view than the Eiffel itself.
- **Seine River Cruise at Night:** Catch the second-last one — the city changes after dark.

Paris 2025: Returning to Find What We Missed the First Time

The second time you visit a city, you see it differently. The first time, you're chasing icons—the Eiffel Tower, the Louvre, the Seine at sunset. You're ticking boxes, assembling a version of the place from photographs you've seen your whole life, checking whether reality matches imagination. The second time, you already know. And in knowing, you get to choose something else.

We returned to Paris in early 2025, and this time we had one deliberate rule: *nothing we'd already done*. No Louvre, no Notre-Dame queue, no Montmartre by day (though we did allow a 7 a.m. walk before anyone arrived). Instead: Canal Saint-Martin, smaller museums, neighborhoods we'd walked past but never into, and at least one full afternoon with nothing planned at all.

Canal Saint-Martin in Winter

The **Canal Saint-Martin** in winter is a completely different animal from its summer self. In warm months, it's lined with Parisians sitting on the iron footbridges eating lunch and watching the canal boats navigate the locks. In February, it's quieter, mist sometimes hanging over the water, bare plane trees making architectural patterns against grey sky. We preferred it, honestly.

We walked the full length—about 4.5 km—stopping at café terraces with heaters outside (the French commitment to outdoor dining in all climates is admirable). The neighborhood around it: **République, Oberkampf, Goncourt**—is where a younger, working Parisian version of the city lives. Less gloss, more grit, genuinely excellent coffee.

We found a small boulangerie on a side street where the owner was still shaping croissants at 7:30 a.m. She let us wait, gave us the first ones from the oven, and charged us what seemed like an ethical price for something that tasted transcendent. This is what Paris second-timers get.

Musée d'Orsay: What to Do Instead of the Louvre

The **Musée d'Orsay**—housed in a stunning Beaux-Arts railway station—is, we'd argue, the better Paris museum experience. Its collection focuses on Impressionism: Monet's water lilies, Van Gogh's self-portraits, Renoir, Degas, Toulouse-Lautrec, Cézanne. The building itself is extraordinary—the great clock faces of the former station embedded in the upper level, the nave of the old concourse turned into a gallery space.

We spent three hours here and could have stayed longer. The crowd is smaller than the Louvre (pre-book timed entry still advisable), the café is beautiful (lunch under the ornate ceiling of the former station restaurant), and the level of the permanent collection is genuinely world-class.

Père Lachaise Cemetery

Père Lachaise Cemetery is one of those places that sounds morbid in planning and becomes, in practice, one of the more genuinely moving experiences Paris offers. It's a vast, leafy necropolis of remarkable funerary art and famous residents. We found Oscar Wilde's tomb (lipstick-kissed, glass-encased, still receiving admirers), Jim Morrison's grave, the monuments to victims of the Holocaust and deportation.

But more than the famous names, we wandered the older sections, where families over three centuries have built extraordinary mausoleums: miniature Gothic chapels, statues frozen mid-grief, photographs faded but still present. Paris takes death as seriously as it takes pleasure, and it shows.

The Covered Passages

Paris in the 19th century was full of **passages couverts**—covered shopping arcades with glass roofs and mosaic floors, built before department stores changed everything. About twenty survive. We visited the **Galerie Vivienne** and **Passage des Panoramas**—both stunning, both slightly out of time, both excellent for sheltering from February rain.

These passages are where philatelists, rare book dealers, art print sellers, and vintage map shops still do quiet business. We bought a vintage illustrated postcard from the 1920s and felt we'd found something Paris was keeping just for us.

What to Do on Your Second Paris Visit

- **Canal Saint-Martin Walk:** Best in morning or winter quiet.
- **Musée d'Orsay:** Impressionism in a railway station.
- **Père Lachaise Cemetery:** Art, history & famous graves.
- **Galerie Vivienne:** 19th-century covered arcade.
- **Oberkampf Neighborhood:** Local cafés, less tourism.
- **Palais Royal Gardens:** Quiet colonnaded arcades & gardens.
- **Sainte-Chapelle:** Stained glass that will stop your breath.
- **Marché des Enfants Rouges:** Paris's oldest covered market.

Strasbourg: Half-Timbered Houses, Tarte Flambée & a Cathedral That Stopped Us Cold

Strasbourg is what happens when two countries can't agree on a city and eventually decide to share it. Historically passed between France and Germany four times in the last 150 years, Strasbourg now sits in France's Alsace region, speaking French, eating choucroute, and yet surrounded by half-timbered houses and a Gothic cathedral that clearly learned its ambitions from the Rhine Valley. It's a fascinating, confident, beautiful hybrid—and we fell for it immediately.

We arrived from Stuttgart by TGV, a journey of about 50 minutes that feels like a genuine miracle of engineering every time. Strasbourg's Gare Centrale is itself a lovely piece of German Historicist architecture (built during the German occupation, repurposed efficiently). The cathedral appeared on the horizon ten minutes into our walk from the station, and we walked toward it without stopping.

Strasbourg Cathedral: 142 Meters of Gothic Ambition

The **Cathédrale Notre-Dame de Strasbourg** was, for 227 years, the world's tallest building. Begun in 1015 and completed (mostly) in 1439, it is astonishing: a single spire reaching 142 meters, covered in filigree sandstone carving so detailed that you can stand at the base and lose an hour just tracing patterns.

Inside: the famous **Astronomical Clock**—a Rube-Goldberg masterpiece of 16th-century engineering that, at 12:30 each day, runs through a mechanical procession of figures representing the ages of man, the days of the week, and the Death figure striking the hour. We watched it with around 200 other people and felt a shared, slightly awed silence when it finished.

We climbed the platform at the base of the spire—330 steps, a straight vertical assault. But the view over the city's terracotta rooftops, with the Rhine visible in the distance and the Black Forest beyond it, was worth every step and the subsequent inability to properly feel our legs.

La Petite France: The Postcard District

La Petite France is the historic tanners' district of Strasbourg—a small island in the Ill river where medieval half-timbered houses with overhanging upper stories and flower-box windows lean over narrow canal streets. It's immediately, unambiguously charming. It's also one of the most photographed neighborhoods in France, which means it gets crowded, but somehow manages to retain its character anyway.

We walked it in the early evening, when the golden light was catching the flowers in the window boxes and the tourists had thinned slightly. Found a small restaurant serving **tarte flambée**—Alsace's version of pizza, thin and crisp, topped with crème fraîche, lardons, and onion—and ate two, standing up, because the table wait was long and we were hungry and impatient. Worth it completely.

The Alsatian Table

Alsatian food deserves its own celebration. It's a cuisine that combines French technique with German portion philosophy, and the results are deeply satisfying. We had:

Baeckeoffe—a slow-cooked casserole of three meats (pork, lamb, and beef), marinated in Alsatian white wine and baked with vegetables in a sealed terrine. It tastes like the kind of food that would make you feel better about anything. We found it at a *winstub*—a traditional Alsatian wine tavern—in the old town, ate it with crusty bread and a glass of **Riesling**, and genuinely didn't want the meal to end.

Also: pretzels made to a different standard than anywhere else, **kugelhopf** (a sweet yeast cake studded with almonds and raisins, eaten for breakfast or dessert without distinction), and Alsatian wine everywhere, light and clean and frankly excellent.

The European Quarter

Strasbourg hosts the **European Parliament**, the **Council of Europe**, and the **European Court of Human Rights**—a cluster of institutions that make it, officially, a capital of European democracy. The modern institutional buildings are architecturally interesting (the Parliament building, in particular, looks like someone assembled it from a kit of ambitious shapes), and walking through the European quarter gives you a sense of what the postwar vision of a united continent actually materialized into: these glass-and-steel buildings full of diplomats negotiating in seventeen languages.

We didn't go in (tours require advance booking), but walked the perimeter, felt appropriately multilateral, and then went back to eat more tarte flambée.

Must-Visit Places in Strasbourg

- **Cathédrale Notre-Dame:** Climb 330 steps; stay for the Astronomical Clock.
- **La Petite France:** Half-timbered canal district (go at golden hour).
- **Tarte Flambée at a Winstub:** The essential Alsatian experience.
- **Baeckeoﬀe Casserole:** Slow-cooked Alsatian winter warmth.
- **European Parliament Quarter:** Modern architecture & EU history.
- **Ill River Boat Tour:** City-wide canal perspective.
- **Barrage Vauban:** 17th-century weir with rooftop city views.
- **Place de la Cathédrale:** Outdoor cafés under the cathedral spire.

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